

N8N COMPLETE COURSE · MODULE 1 — FOUNDATIONS

# The n8n Interface Tour

Lesson 03 · Know your workshop before you build

Canvas Mastery

Essential Shortcuts

Save vs Publish

SolutionsWithShahzain

# Today's Tour Stops



## The map of your instance

Left panel, top bar — where everything lives



## The canvas

Your workspace: pan, zoom, stay oriented



## Finding & adding nodes

The node panel — your parts shop



## Save vs Publish + Executions

The 2.x concept most beginners get wrong

# Your Instance Has 3 Areas

## Left Panel

*The office*

Workflows list, credentials, executions, templates — everything you own, organized

## Canvas

*The workshop*

Where you drag nodes, connect them, and build — you'll live here 90% of the time

## Top Bar

*The controls*

Workflow name, Save, Publish, settings — the switches that make things official

*Office · workshop · controls — once this map is in your head, you can never get lost.*

# Canvas Navigation — Never Get Lost



## Pan (move around)

`Ctrl + Drag · Space + Drag · middle mouse`



## Zoom in / out

`+ / - · Ctrl + Mouse Wheel`



## Reset view to 100%

`Press 0`



## Fit all nodes on screen

`Press 1 — your 'where am I?' rescue key`

# The Node Panel — Your Parts Shop

- Press N (or click +) — the panel opens
- Type to search: 'Gmail', 'Sheets', 'HTTP'...
- Enter inserts the selected node onto the canvas
- Drag from a node's edge to connect it to the next
- Esc closes the panel



## Search beats browsing

1,200+ nodes exist. Nobody scrolls categories — power users type 3 letters and hit Enter. Build that habit today.

# Save vs Publish



## Save

- Stores your changes as a new version
- Save as often as you like — it's your draft
- Nothing goes live from saving



## Publish

- Makes ONE chosen version live in production
- Only the published version runs automatically
- Edit after publishing? Production stays unchanged...

**...until you publish again.** Draft changes never touch production on their own. This will save you from a very bad day.

# Executions — Your CCTV Footage

- Every run of a workflow gets recorded here
- Green = success · Red = failed — visible at a glance
- Click any execution to see exactly what happened
- Filter by workflow, status, or date



## Why 'CCTV'?

Workflows run at 3am while you sleep. Executions panel is the recording you check in the morning — what ran, what worked, what broke.

# The Only 8 Shortcuts You Need Today

| Action           | Shortcut                  | Action          | Shortcut               |
|------------------|---------------------------|-----------------|------------------------|
| Save workflow    | <code>Ctrl + S</code>     | Open node panel | <code>N</code>         |
| Execute workflow | <code>Ctrl + Enter</code> | Rename node     | <code>F2</code>        |
| Undo             | <code>Ctrl + Z</code>     | Sticky note     | <code>Shift + S</code> |
| Fit all nodes    | <code>1</code>            | Reset zoom      | <code>0</code>         |

*Full shortcut reference lives in this lesson's notes on GitHub — link in description.*



# Common Beginner Mistakes



## Getting lost and panicking

A messy canvas isn't broken — press 1 to fit view, then breathe.



## Editing a published workflow and assuming it's live

It's not. Draft ≠ production. Publish again to ship your changes.



## Zero sticky notes on a 20-node canvas

Future you (and clients) won't remember what node 14 does. Label as you build.



## Never opening the executions panel

Then wondering why 'nothing happened'. The answer was recorded all along.

# Your Assignment — Canvas Warm-Up



10 minutes of deliberate practice in your own instance.

1

**Add any 3 nodes via N + search**

Rename each with F2 — give them funny names, why not

2

**Add a sticky note (Shift + S)**

Write today's date and one thing you learned

3

**Get lost, then recover**

Zoom way in, pan far away — then press 1 like a pro

*Comment your favorite shortcut — mine is 1. Fight me.*

# Key Takeaways

1

3 areas: left panel (office), canvas (workshop), top bar (controls)

2

N to find nodes, 1 to never be lost, Ctrl+Enter to run

3

Save = draft version · Publish = live — never confuse the two

4

Executions panel = your CCTV — every run is recorded there

THE ONE YOU'VE BEEN WAITING FOR

# Lesson 04 — Your First Workflow

## No more theory. We build.

- A real, working automation — start to finish
- Trigger + actions, exactly like Lesson 1 promised
- It will run on its own. While you watch. It's a moment.



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